

A+E

FUNNIEST GUY FROM JOLIET

Jim Downey transformed 50 years of "SNL." He is the eccentric's eccentric. The comedy writer's comedy writer. The Illinois native who made late-night television smart.



TERRENCE ANTONIO JAMES/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

LIFE+TRAVEL

‘All mothers sacrifice’

Despite hardship, my mom made sure I had the things that really matter, Tribune reporter Gregory Royal Pratt writes.

REAL ESTATE

‘Married to the rate’

Chicago housing market gets off to a slightly busier start early in 2025.



Gladys Reconquista-Bayot and her nephew Aaron Reconquista take a selfie outside Holy Name Cathedral in Chicago, where a digital image of Pope Leo XIV was posted after a Mass of Thanksgiving on Friday. **ANTONIO PEREZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

A ‘Midwesterner who is not afraid of hard work’

Cardinal Cupich says Chicago should be proud to have produced new pope

By Angie Leventis Lourgos
Chicago Tribune

As newly elected Pope Leo XIV — a native son of Chicago — made his first appearance on the loggia at St. Peter’s Basilica, Cardinal Blase Cupich looked on from an adjacent balcony, keenly aware of the monumental moment.

The archbishop of Chicago gazed down at the piazza and crowd that spilled to the Tiber River, jam-packed with more than 250,000 faithful awaiting the first words of the new pontiff.

“To be in that position is something that I’ll never be able to replicate in the future,” Cupich said during a phone interview with the Tribune from Vatican City. “It’s a once-in-a-lifetime experience to be on the same platform where the new pope



Cardinals Blase Cupich, of Chicago, left, and Joseph Tobin, of Newark, New Jersey, attend a news conference in Rome on Friday. **GREGORIO BORGIA/AP**

MORE COVERAGE INSIDE

Chicago loudly and proudly claims pope — and the “Pope’s Pizza” — at Aurelio’s. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

Pope Leo XIV reveals his vision for the church, naming AI as a critical challenge. **Nation & World**

is going to be announced with hundreds of thousands of people chanting his name.”

Following the papal conclave’s historic selection, Cupich declared that Chicago should be “proud to have produced” the new pope, a South Sider who became the first American pontiff in the 2,000-year history of the Catholic Church.

“Let’s be proud that Chicago produced a person of this quality that could be pope,” he said. “We should be very proud of that.”

The archbishop of Chicago played an historic role Thursday as a member of the conclave that selected Dolton’s own Robert Francis Prevost, long-time missionary and member of the Augustinian order, to lead the Church.

Turn to Pope, Page 2

Johnson fights new battles in 2nd year

Thorniest issues mayor faces have come from unexpected fronts

By Alice Yin, Jake Sheridan and A.D. Quig
Chicago Tribune

One recent Sunday afternoon, Mayor Brandon Johnson strode into a scene that seemed tailor-made for shoring up his political base.

The Chicago Alliance Against Racist and Political Repression had convened an audience of grassroots activists and Black faith leaders inside a Far South Side church, where organizer Frank Chapman promised “a direct response to the attacks on the Brandon Johnson administration.”

But Johnson had hardly smoothed out his prepared notes before a grieving woman began shouting him down over a recent fatal Chicago police shooting. The mayor did not regain control of the room for another five minutes.

“I do recognize that expectations for a Black man are quite profound,” Johnson said after the woman left. “I’m certainly not intimidated by a moment where our people are expressing their hurt.”

Johnson arrives at his second anniversary in office this Thursday, and his response that day reflected a chief executive who has often endeavored to project strength and temper hopes on what he can achieve by his term’s halfway mark.

Though the harsh spotlight on Johnson’s office on the fifth floor is nothing new, some of the thorniest issues the former Chicago Teachers Union organizer has battled his second year have come from unexpected fronts: education, and the city’s political left. Those difficulties at times dominated his administration’s attention and pushed him to expend political capital in ways he may not have predicted when he came into office as the city’s most progressive mayor in 40 years.

A bitter feud with Chicago Public Schools leadership dogged Johnson for months. The road to settling a new Chicago Teachers Union contract without a strike

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INSIDE

STACEY WESCOTT/TRIBUNE

Great expectations

With Colston Loveland focusing on mental reps, it’s easy to dream big about the Bears rookie tight end. **Brad Biggs in Chicago Sports**

Urging a ceasefire

Four European countries threatened to ratchet up pressure on Russia if it does not accept an unconditional 30-day ceasefire. **Nation & World**

In Illinois, invisible boundary affects power grid

Where one resides determines how dirty and costly electricity is

By John Lippert
Chicago Tribune

The town of Ottawa lies in central Illinois 12 miles from a nuclear power plant and a wind turbine farm that stretches past the horizon. However, these facilities sit on the other side of an invisible boundary between two regional power grids.

By mutual agreement among utilities that own the grids and power plants, that nuclear plant and wind station sell much of their power to Chicago, Ohio and the East Coast. Ottawa gets most of its power from southern

Illinois, western states and even the Canadian province of Manitoba, whose electricity may now be subject to a U.S. tariff.

The power Ottawa gets is also dirtier, less reliable and more expensive than that of its neighbors.

It’s a story being told across the state.

Because central and southern Illinois differ from their northern counterparts in how they make and buy electricity, they’re slipping behind in the race for cheap and reliable power, clean air and economic growth.

In a few years, towns on both sides of the boundary could be overwhelmed by surging power demand from artificial

Turn to Power, Page 12



A solar farm is being built to provide power for the Pilkington Glass facility in Ottawa, Illinois. **E. JASON WAMBSGANS/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**